

100 ASVAB Word Knowledge Power Words

Master these and you'll recognize roughly 70% of WK questions on test day. Real high-frequency vocab, one-line definitions, and a memory hook for every word.

How WK questions actually work

Every Word Knowledge question gives you a target word (often inside a short sentence with the word in **bold**) and four answer choices. The choices are almost always single-word synonyms.

The 11-second move: read the sentence, mentally cover the bold word, predict your own synonym from context, *then* match it to the closest answer. Don't read all four choices first — their job is to confuse you. Bring your answer to them.

List 1 of 2 — Words 1–50. Memory hooks use anchor words, mnemonics, or roots. Learn the hook, you own the word.

WORD	POS	DEFINITION	MEMORY HOOK
Abate	v.	to lessen, reduce	"a-bate" → bait getting smaller, fish lose interest
Augment	v.	to add to, increase	"aug" = bigger (think August harvest piling up)
Mitigate	v.	to make less severe	mitt + gate → oven mitt blocks the heat coming through
Exacerbate	v.	to make worse	"ex-acid-bait" → pour acid on it, gets nastier
Enhance	v.	to improve, raise quality	en + hands → put more hands on it, makes it better
Diminish	v.	to make smaller	shares root with "mini" → shrink it down
Alleviate	v.	to relieve, ease	"a-levitate" → lift the weight off your shoulders
Intensify	v.	to make stronger	turn the tension dial up
Curtail	v.	to cut short	"cut + tail" → trim the tail off, shorter
Amplify	v.	to make louder, increase	think guitar amp → bigger sound
Conceal	v.	to hide	concealed carry → weapon out of sight
Divulge	v.	to reveal a secret	"di-vulgar" → spill the gossip
Obscure	adj./v.	unclear, hidden; to hide	"ob-secure" → locked away from view
Illuminate	v.	to light up, clarify	"lumen" = unit of light → throw light on it
Reveal	v.	to show	re + veil → pull the veil back off
Mask	v.	to cover, disguise	literal mask over the face
Unveil	v.	to uncover, reveal	opposite of veil → off comes the cover
Camouflage	v./n.	to disguise, blend in	military pattern that hides the soldier
Veil	v./n.	to cover, conceal	wedding veil over the face
Cloak	v./n.	to hide, cover	"cloak and dagger" → spy hiding everything
Traverse	v.	to cross over	trans- (across) + verse → go across
Deviate	v.	to stray from a path	"de + via" (off the road) → off course
Advance	v.	to move forward	"ad-" = toward → press forward
Retreat	v.	to pull back	"re-" = back → pull the troops back
Pursue	v.	to chase, follow	"per-sue" → sue them through every court
Evade	v.	to dodge, avoid	SERE: Survive, Evade, Resist, Escape → slip away
Engage	v.	to enter into combat or contact	"engage the enemy" → lock on, make contact
Withdraw	v.	to pull out, remove	withdraw from an ATM → pull money out
Maneuver	v./n.	to move skillfully into position	"man + euver" → hand-worked move (Latin manu + opera)

WORD	POS	DEFINITION	MEMORY HOOK
Flank	<i>v.</i>	to attack from the side	steak flank → the side of something
Ambiguous	<i>adj.</i>	open to multiple meanings	"ambi-" = both → could go either way
Dubious	<i>adj.</i>	doubtful, uncertain	shares root with "doubt" → "I dub thee suspect"
Definitive	<i>adj.</i>	final, decisive	"definition" → settled, no debate left
Conclusive	<i>adj.</i>	settling the matter	brings the conclusion → case closed
Indeterminate	<i>adj.</i>	not decided, vague	"in-" + determine → not yet determined
Equivocal	<i>adj.</i>	vague, two-faced	"equi-" (equal) + voice → says two things at once
Tactical	<i>adj.</i>	short-term, mission-level plan	tactical = on-the-ground moves
Strategic	<i>adj.</i>	long-term, big-picture plan	strategy = the whole war, not the battle
Vigilant	<i>adj.</i>	watchful, alert	"vigil" → staying up keeping watch
Prudent	<i>adj.</i>	cautious, wise	think "prude" → careful, doesn't take risks
Deliberate	<i>adj.</i>	intentional, careful	de-liberate → freed of haste, takes time
Contingent	<i>adj.</i>	dependent on something	"contingency plan" → depends on what happens
Resolute	<i>adj.</i>	firm, determined	shares root with "resolve" → mind made up
Stoic	<i>adj.</i>	showing no emotion	think Spartan warrior → takes pain silently
Valiant	<i>adj.</i>	brave, courageous	"valor" → the brave soldier
Massive	<i>adj.</i>	huge, enormous	has "mass" → big amount of stuff
Minute	<i>adj.</i>	tiny (mai-NOOT, not min-it)	"min-" = small → smaller than a minute
Swift	<i>adj.</i>	fast	swift bird → one of the fastest fliers
Sluggish	<i>adj.</i>	slow, lazy	literal slug → barely moves
Fleeting	<i>adj.</i>	brief, passing quickly	"flee" → gone before you blink

More drills + practice tests: asvabhero.com/practice-test

Power words 51–100: sneaky synonyms & high-value roots

The bottom half of the list leans into the words WK loves most: ones that sound like their opposite, and the Latin/Greek roots that decode hundreds of words you've never seen.

WORD	POS	DEFINITION	MEMORY HOOK
Condone	<i>v.</i>	to forgive or permit (NOT condemn)	sneaky pair: condone = OK with it; condemn = damn it
Peruse	<i>v.</i>	to read carefully (NOT skim)	"per-" = thoroughly → read all the way through
Nonplussed	<i>adj.</i>	confused (NOT calm)	"non-plus" → can't add it up, baffled
Enervate	<i>v.</i>	to drain energy (NOT energize)	"e-nerve-ate" → eats your nerves out
Noisome	<i>adj.</i>	smelly, disgusting (NOT noisy)	think "annoy-some" smell → not about sound at all
Fulsome	<i>adj.</i>	excessive, over-the-top (NOT generous)	"full-some" praise → so much it's gross
Plethora	<i>n.</i>	excess, too much	say it slow: "plethora" → piles and piles
Paucity	<i>n.</i>	scarcity, too little	"pau-" = few (think paucity vs. plethora)
Myriad	<i>n./adj.</i>	a huge number	Greek for 10,000 → uncountable
Sparse	<i>adj.</i>	thinly spread, few	spare + scarce → barely there
Candid	<i>adj.</i>	honest, frank	candid camera → catches you being real
Discreet	<i>adj.</i>	tactful, careful with info	"discrete" with two e's → secretive
Adept	<i>adj.</i>	highly skilled	"adapt" + accept → takes it on and nails it
Inept	<i>adj.</i>	unskilled, clumsy	"in-" + adept → the opposite
Robust	<i>adj.</i>	strong, hearty	"robot + bust" → built strong, won't break
Frail	<i>adj.</i>	weak, easily broken	shares sound with "fail" → gives way
Lucid	<i>adj.</i>	clear, easy to understand	"luc-" = light (Lucifer = light bringer)
Opaque	<i>adj.</i>	not clear, blocking light	frosted glass → can't see through
Tedious	<i>adj.</i>	boring, tiresome	tedious meeting → drags on forever
Riveting	<i>adj.</i>	fascinating, gripping	"rivet" → nails your attention down
Banal	<i>adj.</i>	boring, unoriginal	"banana-l" → plain, common, no spice
Novel	<i>adj.</i>	new, original	like a new novel on the shelf
Trivial	<i>adj.</i>	unimportant	like Trivial Pursuit → nice to know, doesn't matter
Crucial	<i>adj.</i>	extremely important	at the crux → the deciding point
Compel	<i>v.</i>	to force	"com-pel" → push someone all the way
Coerce	<i>v.</i>	to force by threat	"co-erce" → arm-twisted into it
Foster	<i>v.</i>	to encourage growth	foster parent → helps the child develop
Stifle	<i>v.</i>	to suppress, smother	"stuff" + "rifle" → muzzle it, cut it off
Quell	<i>v.</i>	to put down, calm	quell a riot → kill the chaos
Provoke	<i>v.</i>	to stir up, anger	"pro-" + voke (call) → calls a reaction out
Scrutinize	<i>v.</i>	to examine closely	"scrutiny" → eyes all over it
Glance	<i>v.</i>	to look briefly	quick flick of the eyes
Tenacious	<i>adj.</i>	persistent, holding firm	"ten-" = hold (tendon holds bone) → won't let go
Reluctant	<i>adj.</i>	unwilling, hesitant	"re-luct" (struggle back) → dragging your feet
Sanction	<i>v./n.</i>	to officially approve OR penalize	two-faced word → context decides which

WORD	POS	DEFINITION	MEMORY HOOK
Incite	<i>v.</i>	to stir up, urge to action	"in-" + cite → light the fire under them
Placate	<i>v.</i>	to soothe, calm down	"placid" → make them peaceful again
Vex	<i>v.</i>	to annoy, frustrate	"v-ex" → like an X across your day
Abhor	<i>v.</i>	to hate strongly	"ab-" (away) + horror → recoil in disgust
Revere	<i>v.</i>	to deeply respect	"reverend" → treated with awe
Root: ben-	<i>root</i>	good (benefit, benevolent, benign)	Spanish "bien" = good → remember "ben Franklin was a good man"
Root: mal-	<i>root</i>	bad (malice, malign, malfunction)	Spanish "mal" = bad → "mal-ware" wrecks your laptop
Root: -voke	<i>root</i>	to call (provoke, evoke, revoke)	"voice" → calling something out into action
Root: trans-	<i>root</i>	across (transport, traverse, transmit)	"trans-Atlantic" → going across
Root: spect-	<i>root</i>	look (inspect, prospect, spectacle)	"spec-tator" → one who looks
Root: dict-	<i>root</i>	speak (dictate, predict, contradict)	"diction" → how you speak
Root: port-	<i>root</i>	carry (transport, portable, deport)	a "port" carries cargo in and out
Root: rupt-	<i>root</i>	break (rupture, interrupt, abrupt)	"rupture" → broken open
Root: cred-	<i>root</i>	believe (credible, credit, incredulous)	"credit card" → the bank believes you'll pay
Root: tract-	<i>root</i>	pull/drag (extract, retract, distract)	"tractor" → pulls heavy stuff

Build flashcards from this list: target word on the front, definition + hook on the back. Drill 10 a day for 10 days → whole list owned.

5-question mini quiz (real WK format)

Read the sentence. Predict your own synonym before reading the choices. Then match.

1. The medic worked to mitigate the soldier's pain before evacuation.

- A. worsen
- B. reduce
- C. diagnose
- D. conceal

2. The squad leader gave ambiguous orders that left everyone confused.

- A. decisive
- B. shouted
- C. unclear
- D. brief

3. She was nonplussed by the unexpected question from the panel.

- A. relieved
- B. confused
- C. amused
- D. calm

4. The drill instructor told us to peruse the manual before drill.

- A. skim
- B. copy
- C. read carefully
- D. memorize quotes from

5. His tenacious grip on the rope kept the climber from falling.

- A. weak
- B. persistent
- C. sweaty
- D. casual

Answer key: 1) B reduce — 2) C unclear — 3) B confused (the classic trap is D “calm”) — 4) C read carefully (NOT A skim) — 5) B persistent.

Got 4 or 5? You're already above the WK average. Got 2 or fewer? Run the list one more time, then take a full timed practice test.

Your next move. Take a free timed WK practice test at asvabhero.com/practice-test. Then plug your scores into the calculator at asvabhero.com/calculator to see exactly which jobs your current vocab is unlocking —

and how many points away you are from your dream MOS, rate, or AFSC.

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